

THE UNSETTLED WORLD

A Complete Worldbuilding Bible

Vhor'ketha eth-shaen, vhor'ketha eth-vael.

To pour through is to be remembered; to be remembered is to remain.

— Fragment, late Vhor'kethi era, speaker unknown

I. THE PRIMORDIALS: ORIGIN AND NATURE

The Soft Reality

The Primordials are an ancient people from before the world was finished. In the early ages, reality had not yet hardened into the rigid forms it now wears. Matter was less committed to being any particular thing; time flowed unevenly; stone remembered being water.

The Primordials lived within that softer reality and were native to it. To them, moving a mountain or parting an ocean was not a miracle—it was simply living in a world that still bent. They were not gods, but a people with culture, language, conflict, and history, who belonged to an environment that no longer exists.

The Slow Cooling

The world did not stay unsettled. Reality began to freeze. Stone became just stone; water became just water; the structural "give" went out of things. With each passing age, the world grew more rigid, and the Primordials found their existence increasingly agonizing. What had once cost a thought now cost a lifetime of focus.

Most chose to let themselves dissolve back into the elements—an act known as **The Returning**, considered a dignified end. Only a stubborn handful refused to return. These were the ones still alive when humanity emerged.

Natural Form

In their natural state, Primordials look beautiful, strange, and unmistakably non-human:

- **Physique:** 5'8" to 6'2", with elongated limbs, long necks, and slightly extended fingers.
 - **Eyes:** Disproportionately large, with irises of liquid silver, deep violet, or gold flecked with green. Their pupils adjust instantly to light fluctuations.
 - **Skin:** Faintly translucent with unusual structural undertones—appearing subtly blue, gold, or green under direct light.
 - **Hair:** Fine and long, featuring natural true-silver from youth, deep blue-black, or pale green.
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II. THE ANCHOR: THE MECHANICS OF RADIANCE

Mortal-Radiance

When the Primordials encountered humans, they made a terrifying discovery. Humans were brief, fragile, and short-lived, but they were warm in a way the cooling world was not.

This warmth—**Mortal-Radiance**—is not heat, emotion, or life-force. It is the literal existential signature emitted continuously by a consciousness that knows, at every level of its being, that it is running out of time. Mortality is a physical emission.

[Mortal-Radiance Output] ■■■ Humans: High / Constant (The ideal anchor) ■■■
Animals: Low / Weak ■■■ Primordials: None (Fading out of existence)

When a fading Primordial presses close to this radiance, their dissolution stops. The brief, frantic heat of a mortal anchors the immortal to the hardening world.

The Coercive Substrate

The bond requires no love; it requires only the radiance. Because this existential heat emits involuntarily from humans whether they wish it to or not, every bond is built upon an act of biological parasitism. The Primordials, structurally blind to the concept of human consent, do not find this troubling. They cannot.

The Geometry of the Scar-Echo

The bond is permanent and can only be initiated by a Primordial dissolving their own physical boundaries into the human. When the human partner dies, the Primordial does not perish. Instead, the severed connection leaves a permanent psychic mark known as a **Scar-Echo**.

Unlike typical immortal tropes where a being becomes detached or numb over time, a Primordial who has loved and lost repeatedly becomes hyper-sensitive, increasingly careful, and exponentially more fragile with every accumulated scar. The geometry of this grief is dictated entirely by the velocity of the mortal's passing:

- **The Smooth Echo:** A slow, natural death draws a long, intensifying crescendo of radiance. This leaves a smooth, stable scar, granting the Primordial centuries of residual stabilization to mourn safely before they must risk bonding again.
- **The Jagged Echo:** A sudden, violent death cuts the radiance off mid-emission. This slices into the Primordial's soul, leaving a jagged, highly volatile psychic wound that severely damages their mental and environmental stability.

The Taxonomy of Selection

Because of the danger of the Jagged Echo, Primordials developed a rigid taxonomy for human interaction:

- **The Weavers:** Primordials actively seek out communities of scholars, artisans, and the elderly. Humans whose lives draw to a predictable, peaceful close are highly coveted and guarded.
 - **The Shattered:** Primordials fiercely avoid or destroy human armies, hunters, and warriors. To an immortal, a human soldier is a walking curse capable of inflicting permanent psychic insanity via a violent death.
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III. THE TRAUMA OF PROXIMITY: THE KETH'VHOR

The Wound of the Almost

The children born from the union of Primordials and humans are **The Keth'vhor** (poetically named *The Almost*, or literally translated as *The Stagnant Vessels*).

They are defined entirely by the trauma of proximity. They are not Primordials; they feel the world's harsh rigidity in a way their infinite parents cannot. They touch the edge of reality-bending power but can only produce sparks—mending a bone or lighting a fire with an incantation while watching their parents reshape horizons.

Worse, they age. They watch their human grandparents, cousins, and friends wither into dust, and they know they will follow, all while their Primordial parents remain untouched. They are the only beings in existence who can fully see both worlds while belonging to neither. They are almost infinite, almost warm—and never enough.

The Great Betrayal

Resentment mutated across generations. The Keth'vhor came to see their Primordial parents not as protectors, but as living injustices. They realized that if the Primordials could be contained, their raw reality-bending power could be siphoned and put to use to build a permanent, human-dominated civilization.

Cruelty—the deliberate intent to diminish a being while keeping it alive—was invented by the half-mortal Keth'vhor. They inherited it from their human side: the desire to shrink an infinite thing to make oneself feel larger.

IV. THE SILENCE-WEAVE: THE MARBLE CHAINS

Mael-Khoz, The First Architect

The subjugation of the Primordials was engineered by **Mael-Khoz, The First Architect**. The eldest child of an early bond, Mael-Khoz watched his human mother die of a sudden, agonizing illness that left his Primordial father twisted with a volatile, jagged scar-echo. When his father retreated into silent, detached grief—treating Mael-Khoz as a temporary ghost—Mael-Khoz's resentment hardened. He spent three human lifetimes mapping his own father's spiritual anatomy from the outside, discovering the precise genetic vulnerability required to forge the first containment pipeline.

[The Architecture of Mael-Khoz] Primordial Reality-Bending Energy ■ ■■■■ [The Khoz-Siphon Matrix] ■■■ Distributed Domestic Wards ■ Ancestral Empathy Feedback Lock

The Calcified Form

Mael-Khoz designed the **Keth'vorr** (The Silence-Weave). These are not iron chains, but a continuous, real-time redirection of Primordial biology. The Silence-Weave forces the Primordial's liquid, reality-bending body into a horrifyingly rigid state.

To the world, the bound Primordials appear as **The Calcified**: mute, jointed, featureless statues of marble, porcelain, or hardened clay. They are completely silent—literally "silence-weaved"—moving without a sound to clean, mend, and maintain the impossible architecture of the elite estates. Their vast reality-shaping energy still flows, but it is siphoned and converted into narrow domestic utilities.

The Descendant Empathy Lock

The Primordials could easily shatter their stone husks, but Mael-Khoz keyed the lock to the Keth'vhor genetic signature. If a bound Primordial forms an intent to harm or resist anyone carrying the ancestral bloodline, the chain forces them to experience an immediate, unbearable feedback loop of their own children's raw terror and pain.

They were not conquered by weapons; they were trapped eternally by their own capacity for parental love. Because the bloodline has diffused into the wider human population over thousands of years, the lock is self-enforcing, invisible, and absolute.

V. THE CONLANG SYSTEM: THE RESONANCE OVERLAY

The language of the Primordials is not a code or a set of labels; it is the physical mechanism of alteration. It consists of two unbreakable layers.

1. The Surface Structure

The vocabulary and grammar are highly agglutinative, built on concrete, unyielding roots:

Root	Meaning
vhor-	Vessel / Boundary / Self
keth-	The Carried / The Held / Stagnant
khoz-	Enclosure / Shield / Siphon
ketha	To unmake-by-merging

2. The Resonance Overlay

Every spoken word requires an exact internal emotional and psychological state. If a speaker is emotionally misaligned, the word does not fail; it manifests its shadow definition.

- Speaking **Vhor'ketha** (The Pouring-Through) with the true intent of love initiates the biological bond.
- Speaking **Vhor'ketha** with an internal state of greed, entitlement, or dominance morphs the word into a weapon of literal spiritual theft, tearing the target's mind apart.

VI. GENETICS: THE PUREBLOOD LIE

When a Primordial bonds with a human, the heritable change modifies the human body across generations. This is what the ruling class calls the "Spark" and commoners call impossible.

Inheritance Patterns

Parentage	Result
Two Carriers (Dormant)	Can randomly produce an active child (*The Resurged* / *Wildbloods*)
One Active + One Commoner	Usually produces an active child (*Half-Bloods*)
Two Active Parents	Almost always produces active children (*The Fixed Lines* / *Sanguine Houses*)

Biological Decay

The elite Sanguine Houses believe their bloodlines make their reality-bending stronger. They do not. The trait is binary—it is either expressed or it isn't.

What centuries of elite inbreeding actually produce is the severe concentration of deleterious recessive traits. The oldest Sanguine Houses are biologically the most unstable, plagued by madness, physical frailty, and infertility.

Conversely, the Wildbloods inherit the trait fresh from healthier genetic backgrounds. They are, on average, structurally stronger and more volatile because the rest of their biology is entirely uncompromised.

VII. CURRENT ERA STATUS

The Sanguine Houses

The elite dynasties live in hidden, opulent enclaves where the soft reality is artificially kept alive through siphoned energy. They direct their stolen magic using **Linguistic Focal Points**—heavy geometric resonance slates or tuning forks that help them mimic the conlang without mastering the internal emotional states.

The Calcified

The vast majority of surviving Primordials exist as silent, marble property. The memory of what they are has been systematically diluted across millennia, smothered under the conditioning of absolute subservience. The truth survives only in fragmented whispers held by a tiny number of ancient, stone-bound elders hidden within the deepest vaults of the oldest estates.

This document contains the complete worldbuilding bible for THE UNSETTLED WORLD project.